

Legal Status and Spousal Labor Supply: Evidence from DACA*

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Abstract

This paper examines spillovers from the temporary legal status of an immigrant by investigating how eligibility for the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) program affects the labor supply of an ineligible spouse. The DACA program, introduced in 2012, granted unauthorized immigrants who arrived in the United States as children a renewable work permit and protection from deportation. Linking DACA-eligible and narrowly ineligible immigrants to their cohabiting spouses in American Community Survey data (2006-2019), I estimate difference-in-differences and event-study designs comparing spouses across the two groups before and after DACA's 2012 implementation. I find that a partner's DACA eligibility raised spousal labor force participation by 4.1 percentage points and employment by 3.6 points during initial implementation, effects that persist through the subsequent period of policy uncertainty following the 2017 rescission attempt. The spillover is concentrated almost entirely among female spouses of male DACA-eligible immigrants, and, within these households, among those with children present, consistent with household specialization. During initial implementation, the effect is also concentrated among noncitizen spouses, suggesting a role for reduced exposure to immigration enforcement risk within the household.

Keywords: DACA, immigration policy, spousal labor supply, household spillovers

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1 Introduction

Since 2012, the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) program has provided work authorization and protection from deportation to over 800,000 unauthorized immigrants who arrived in the United States as children. A well-established literature shows that DACA eligibility raised recipients' own labor force participation, employment, and earnings (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman, 2017; Pope, 2016). I examine a margin this literature has left largely unexplored: the labor supply of the spouse who does not receive DACA. Immigrant households pool resources and risk, and a change in one partner's legal status and access to the formal labor market can alter the constraints facing the couple, whether by relaxing a binding household budget constraint, easing informal-sector risk that the household previously bore collectively, or shifting the relative return to one partner's continued labor market withdrawal. *Ex ante*, then, the sign of this spillover is not obvious and is ultimately an empirical question.

To answer this, I compare likely-undocumented immigrants who qualify for the program to those who narrowly miss one or more of its eligibility cutoffs, and link them to their cohabiting spouse using household roster data from the 2006-2019 American Community Survey. Because a spouse who is herself DACA eligible would confound a direct effect of her own status with the spillover effect I aim to isolate, I exclude such spouses from my analysis sample. I then estimate the effect of a partner's DACA eligibility on spousal labor supply using difference-in-differences and event study specifications that compare spouses of eligible immigrants to spouses of narrowly ineligible immigrants, before and after the policy's 2012 implementation, extending the sample through 2019 to capture the period of legal uncertainty following the program's 2017 rescission attempt.

I find that a partner's DACA eligibility increased spousal labor force participation and employment, effects that are economically meaningful and persist through the subsequent period of policy uncertainty following the 2017 rescission attempt. This pooled effect varies substantially by household composition. The spillover appears concentrated primarily

among female spouses of male DACA-eligible individuals, whose labor force participation and employment rise sharply following their partner's eligibility and remain elevated through the end of the sample period; among male spouses of female DACA-eligible individuals, the estimated effect is close to zero and never statistically distinguishable from it. This pattern is consistent with gendered models of intra-household labor supply, though multiple mechanisms, including employment opportunities, household risk, and income, could contribute. Within households with a male DACA-eligible partner, the effect is further concentrated among households with children present, though, as I discuss below, this result warrants some caution given a documented pre-period irregularity.

I next examine heterogeneity by the spouse's own citizenship status, since citizenship shapes exposure to immigration enforcement and helps distinguish competing explanations for the spillover. The response among noncitizen spouses is concentrated in the initial implementation period and attenuates during the subsequent uncertainty period, while citizen spouses show a response that instead emerges later, during the uncertainty period specifically; this contrast in timing suggests a shift in the underlying mechanism over time, though this margin is theoretically motivated rather than definitively established. The results are robust to alternative specifications, including individual-level controls for the DACA-eligible immigrant and commuting-zone-specific time trends, and are not explained by differential selection into marriage or by differential exposure to local labor market conditions across DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible immigrants.

This paper contributes to three strands of literature. First, it extends the literature on DACA's labor market effects, on recipients' labor force participation, employment, and earnings (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman, 2017; Pope, 2016); household poverty (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman, 2016); educational attainment (Kuka et al., 2020); health insurance and health outcomes (Bae, 2020; Giuntella and Lonsky, 2020); children's health (Hainmueller et al., 2017; Hamilton et al., 2021); homeownership (Wang et al., 2022); property crime (Gunadi, 2020); local labor markets (Battaglia, 2023); and marriage patterns

and household composition (Amuedo-Dorantes et al., 2020; Gihleb et al., 2023). This paper is the first, to my knowledge, to isolate the spousal relationship, exclude spouses near the eligibility threshold to separate spillover from direct effects, and show that the spillover's magnitude depends on which household member gains legal status.

Second, it contributes to the literature on intra-household labor supply responses to economic shocks, including the classic 'added worker effect' (Cullen and Gruber, 2000; Lundberg, 1985; Stephens, 2002), its application to immigration enforcement shocks (Orrenius and Zavodny, 2015), and enforcement's effects on household structure and marriage (Amuedo-Dorantes et al., 2020; Bansak and Pearlman, 2022). This paper considers the reverse-signed shock, a gain, rather than a loss, in legal status, and shows the resulting labor supply response is concentrated among male-recipient households with children, consistent with the same specialization logic, and persists through a subsequent period of policy uncertainty rather than depending on it.

Third, it speaks to the public economics literature on individually targeted, temporary legal protections, including liminal legality and Temporary Protected Status (Kerwin et al., 2022; Menjívar, 2006), the labor market and family-formation effects of legalization (Amuedo-Dorantes and Wang, 2025; Kossoudji and Cobb-Clark, 2002), and how policy uncertainty shapes migrant behavior (Giuntella et al., 2021; Patler et al., 2019). Because eligibility is defined at the individual level and DACA confers status that is renewable but not permanent, recipient-only evaluations will understate a policy's full welfare effects to the extent household members respond based on their own characteristics and beliefs about the recipient's status durability. That the household response persists even as DACA's durability was contested suggests these compositional spillovers, and the policy's perceived permanence, matter for measuring its total labor market effect and for comparing temporary protections against alternative designs.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 provides background on DACA and the conceptual channels through which a partner's legal status could affect

spousal labor supply. Section 3 describes the data and sample construction. Section 4 outlines the empirical framework. Section 5 presents the results, and Section 6 concludes.

2 Background

2.1 Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals

Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals was established by presidential memorandum on June 15, 2012, targeting an estimated 1.7 million unauthorized immigrants who had arrived in the United States as children (Giuntella and Lonsky, 2020; Passel et al., 2014). USCIS began accepting applications on August 15, 2012. The program conferred two primary benefits: deferred action, which protected recipients from deportation and allowed them to reside in the country lawfully, and an Employment Authorization Document (EAD), which granted work authorization and enabled recipients to obtain a Social Security number and, in many states, a driver's license or state identification card, easing access to formal employment, credit, and banking. DACA did not create a path to citizenship or extend eligibility for federal welfare programs or federal student aid, though recipients could claim the Earned Income Tax Credit, and several states extended state-funded Medicaid coverage to them.

Grants were initially valid for two years and required renewal thereafter; approximately 93 percent of recipients sought renewal (Kuka et al., 2020), suggesting that most anticipated the program's continuation beyond its initial term. To qualify, applicants had to lack lawful immigration status as of June 15, 2012; have arrived in the United States before age 16; be under 31 as of June 15, 2012; have resided continuously in the country since June 15, 2007; be enrolled in school, have completed high school or a GED, or have been honorably discharged from the military; and have no felony convictions, significant misdemeanors, or three or more other misdemeanors. Applicants had to be at least 15 years old and pay a \$465 fee. More than 90% of processed applications were approved (Pope, 2016).

Figure A.1 shows the resulting trajectory of approvals, which peaked in 2013 and declined steadily thereafter as the initially eligible population was absorbed into the program. In September 2017, the administration announced its intent to rescind DACA. Roughly 689,800 recipients held active status at the time, out of an estimated 800,000 who had benefited from the program since its inception. The resulting legal challenges left DACA's status contested until 2020, a period of substantial uncertainty that this paper's extended sample period is designed to capture.

2.2 DACA and the Household

Because DACA conferred legal benefits on the recipient but not on other household members, its effects on household labor supply depend on how the recipient's improved standing is transmitted to a spouse. This transmission plausibly operates through three channels: an income effect, as the household's financial position improves with the recipient's move into more stable formal employment; a risk-pooling channel, as a spouse who previously limited her own labor force activity to reduce the household's aggregate exposure to immigration enforcement faces a weaker rationale for doing so once her partner's status is regularized, though this rationale does not mechanically extend to a spouse who remains undocumented; and a documentation-access channel, as the recipient's acquisition of a Social Security number and driver's license eases the recipient's own access to formal employment, credit, and identification, with more limited scope to extend to a spouse who remains undocumented.

These channels generate distinct predictions, tested in Section 5. An income effect should reduce spousal labor supply regardless of the spouse's own citizenship. A risk-pooling channel should instead raise labor supply, concentrated among spouses who are themselves undocumented, since citizen spouses never faced an enforcement-risk rationale for limiting their own activity; if this channel operates, the response should also persist rather than fade once the recipient's own status becomes contested, since the household's

relative risk exposure remains altered. A documentation-access channel predicts a similar direction of effect, but because its benefits are conferred at the individual rather than household level, I find no consistent empirical signature of it operating independently of risk-pooling: heterogeneity by state driver's-license access for undocumented immigrants and by household vehicle ownership, explored in unreported specifications, yields no evidence distinguishable from noise. I therefore treat documentation-access as a channel that is theoretically motivated but not independently identified in this setting, rather than a margin the results below can speak to directly.

3 Data

3.1 Data Source

I use 1% American Community Survey (ACS) samples from IPUMS-USA (Ruggles et al., 2023) spanning 2006 to 2019, restricted to the lower 48 states. These nationally representative individual-level data contain the variables needed to identify DACA-eligible and comparable ineligible groups, include the household roster information necessary to link spouses, provide a sufficiently large sample of these immigrants and their spouses, and cover the full pre-implementation, implementation, and post-rescission-uncertainty periods at annual frequency.

3.2 Identifying the Eligible and Comparison Groups

Because the Census Bureau does not collect information on legal status, I construct a proxy for likely undocumented status using the residual method common in the immigration literature (Borjas and Cassidy, 2019), restricting to foreign-born, non-citizen individuals who arrived after 1980, are not from Cuba, are not veterans, and do not receive Supplemental Security Income or other welfare income. Within this residual pool, I further restrict the

sample to Hispanic immigrants. Undocumented immigrants in the United States are disproportionately of Hispanic origin, particularly from Mexico and Central America, and the population potentially eligible for DACA is similarly concentrated among these countries of origin (Passel et al., 2014). Restricting to Hispanic immigrants therefore improves the accuracy of the residual method in isolating the population of interest and aligns the analysis sample with the demographic composition most directly affected by the policy.¹

Within this restricted pool, I identify DACA-eligible individuals and those narrowly ineligible for the program using the age-at-arrival and residence-length discontinuities embedded in the policy's eligibility criteria. DACA-eligible immigrants are those who arrived in the United States before age 16, were under 31 as of June 2012, and had resided in the United States for at least five years as of 2012; DACA-ineligible immigrants are those who satisfy the age-as-of-2012 criterion but narrowly fail either the arrival-age or residence-duration requirement. Restricting both groups to the same implied age-as-of-2012 range ensures that eligible and ineligible immigrants are drawn from the same birth cohort, so that differences in outcomes cannot be attributed to age-related differences in labor market experience or life-cycle stage rather than DACA eligibility itself. Both groups are restricted to individuals who are aged 18 to 38,² have an implied age as of June 2012 under 31, and arrived in the United States at age 17 or younger, so that neither discontinuity variable is left unbounded. I also restrict the sample to individuals who had either completed high school or were currently enrolled in school, following DACA eligibility rules.

¹This follows the approach of several DACA papers such as Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman (2017) and Kuka et al. (2020).

²I choose this range because those who were 31 as of June 2012 would have been 38 in 2019, the final sample year.

3.3 Linking Spouses

For each DACA-eligible or DACA-ineligible immigrant who is married with a spouse present in the household, I identify their spouse using the household-roster spouse pointer variable in the ACS, matching on household serial number, survey year, and the spouse's person number within the household. This linkage is performed against the full, unrestricted ACS sample rather than the filtered partner sample, so that a spouse is retained regardless of their own citizenship, education, or other characteristics. The resulting sample consists of one observation per identified spouse. I further restrict the analysis sample to opposite-sex couples, who comprise the overwhelming majority of linked partner-spouse pairs in the data (98.55%). Same-sex couples are excluded because the household-specialization channels motivating this paper's heterogeneity analysis, and the broader added-worker-effect literature on which it draws, are conventionally framed around gendered division of labor within opposite-sex households.

Because a spouse who independently satisfies the DACA eligibility criteria would confound a direct effect of her own legal status with the spillover effect of her partner's status, I apply the same eligibility test to each spouse and exclude from the main analysis sample any spouse who is classified as DACA-eligible (12.19% of the sample before this exclusion). This exclusion ensures that the estimated coefficient reflects the effect of a partner's eligibility on a spouse who is not herself a plausible direct beneficiary of the program. The primary outcomes are the spouse's own labor force participation, an indicator equal to one if the spouse is employed or actively seeking work; and employment, an indicator equal to one if the spouse is currently working.

3.4 Geographic Assignment and Sample Weighting

ACS respondents are identified at the Public Use Microdata Area (PUMA) level rather than at the commuting zone (CZ) level used in parts of the DACA literature to capture local labor market conditions. I assign each observation to one or more CZs using the crosswalks

developed by Autor and Dorn (2013) and Tolbert and Sizer (1996). Because a single PUMA can overlap multiple CZs, this procedure assigns some individuals to more than one CZ, with each assignment carrying a population-based allocation factor. To avoid inflating the effective sample size from this fractional allocation, I construct an adjusted person weight equal to the product of the ACS person weight and the PUMA-to-CZ population allocation factor, and I use this adjusted weight in all regressions reported below.³

3.5 Summary Statistics

Table 1 reports pre-period (2006-2011) means and standard deviations for spouses of narrowly defined DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible immigrants, separately by partner eligibility status. Consistent with the narrow-band design described in Section 3.2, the two groups are similar across most observable characteristics. Pre-period labor force participation and employment rates differ only modestly across groups (0.789 versus 0.810 for labor force participation; 0.736 versus 0.748 for employment), and the age distributions of spouses are close (27.2 versus 26.5 years on average).

Some differences are apparent and are addressed directly in the empirical specification. Spouses are drawn from a highly Hispanic-origin population by construction (93.7% and 90.9% Latino among spouses of ineligible and eligible partners, respectively), consistent with the demographic composition of the population targeted by the residual undocumented-status proxy. Spouses of DACA-eligible partners report somewhat higher educational attainment and modestly higher English proficiency (65.8% report speaking English well, versus 54.3% among spouses of ineligible partners), consistent with the partners' own age-at-arrival and length-of-residence eligibility criteria correlating with earlier exposure to U.S. schooling. Household composition measures such as the number of children are also close across groups (1.30 versus 1.27).

³The count of raw observations reported in each table therefore exceeds the number of unique individual-year observations in the underlying survey data. I report both the number of observations and the number of unique individual-years.

DACA-eligible individuals, by construction, are slightly younger on average (23.9 versus 24.3 years), report lower rates of stopping at a high school degree without further schooling (74.3% versus 81.9%), reflecting the same underlying eligibility criteria, and have resided in the United States considerably longer (17.8 versus 11.0 years, reflecting DACA’s residence-duration requirement).

4 Empirical Framework

4.1 Difference-in-Differences Specification

To examine whether DACA eligibility affects spousal labor supply, the main estimating equation is

$$y_{ict} = \beta_1 (DACA_i \times Post_t) + \beta_2 (DACA_i \times Uncertain_t) + \mathbf{X}'_{ict}\gamma + \mathbf{W}'_{ct}\alpha + \delta_c + \tau_t + \varepsilon_{ict} \quad (1)$$

Here, y_{ict} is the labor market outcome for spouse i , who resides in CZ c , observed in survey year t . $DACA_i$ is an indicator equal to one if spouse i ’s partner is DACA-eligible, and zero otherwise. $Post_t$ is an indicator for survey years 2012 through 2017, the period of active DACA implementation, while $Uncertain_t$ is an indicator for survey years 2018 and 2019, the period of policy uncertainty following the administration’s September 2017 announcement of its intent to rescind DACA; separating these two periods lets the specification distinguish a labor supply response that is durable from one that is contingent on DACA’s perceived permanence.

$\mathbf{X}_{ict}$ is a vector of the spouse’s own individual characteristics, including age, age squared, educational attainment categories, English proficiency, and race and ethnicity indicators, which control for the spouse’s own observable human capital and help isolate the effect of the partner’s eligibility from these individual-level confounders. $\mathbf{W}_{ct}$ is a vector of county- and commuting-zone-level policy and labor market controls, including indicators

for county- or state-level, immigration policy, the county-level sanctuary-jurisdiction population share, a Bartik-style shift-share labor demand shock variable, the state minimum wage, and quadratic trends in the 2000-2006 change in CZ-level housing price index, which together account for local enforcement intensity, cost-of-living dynamics, and labor demand conditions that could independently drive spousal labor supply and that may be correlated with where DACA-eligible and ineligible immigrants happen to live.⁴

The term δ_c denotes commuting-zone fixed effects, absorbing time-invariant differences across the CZs in the sample, so that identification comes from within-CZ variation in DACA eligibility rather than from DACA-eligible and ineligible immigrants and their spouses being sorted into systematically different places; this offers a finer level of geographic control than state fixed effects would provide. τ_t are year fixed effects, netting out labor market shocks common to all CZs in a given survey year that would otherwise be conflated with the effect of DACA’s 2012 rollout. All regressions are weighted using the adjusted person weight described in Section 3, and standard errors are clustered at the state level.⁵ The coefficients of interest, β_1 and β_2 , capture the effect of having a DACA-eligible partner on the spouse’s own labor market outcomes during the implementation and uncertainty periods.

Because the ACS does not identify actual DACA recipients, the estimated coefficients should be interpreted as intention-to-treat (ITT) effects of having a DACA-eligible partner rather than treatment-on-the-treated effects of DACA receipt. Although the treatment group is constructed using the standard method to approximate the DACA-eligible undocumented population, not all eligible individuals ultimately applied for or received DACA. Existing evidence suggests that approximately 70% of eligible individuals received DACA (Pope, 2016), implying that the estimated ITT effects represent a lower bound on the true effects among actual recipients and are therefore conservative.

⁴These variables are described in Appendix B.

⁵I cluster standard errors at the state level rather than at the CZ level because policy shocks relevant to this setting are common to every CZ within a state; residuals are therefore likely correlated across CZs sharing a state, and clustering at the coarser state level guards against understating the resulting uncertainty.

4.2 Event Study Specification

Identification of β_1 and β_2 relies on the assumption that, absent DACA, labor market outcomes for spouses of narrowly eligible and narrowly ineligible immigrants would have trended similarly. The narrow-band design (Section 3.2) and the exclusion of spouses who independently satisfy or narrowly miss the DACA eligibility criteria (Section 3.2) limit the scope for confounding from household composition, economic circumstances, or a direct effect of the spouse's own eligibility. I assess the plausibility of the parallel trends assumption directly using the following event study specification:

$$y_{ict} = \sum_{\substack{k=2006 \\ k \neq 2011}}^{2019} \beta_k (DACA_i \times \mathbf{1}[t = k]) + \mathbf{X}'_{ict}\gamma + \mathbf{W}'_{ct}\alpha + \delta_c + \tau_t + \varepsilon_{ict} \quad (2)$$

where $\mathbf{1}[t = k]$ is an indicator equal to one if the survey year equals k , and all other variables, including the commuting-zone and year fixed effects, weighting, and clustering, are defined as in Equation (1). The coefficients β_k trace out the year-specific treatment effect of having a DACA-eligible partner, relative to 2011, the last full pre-implementation survey year, which serves as the omitted reference category.

Coefficients β_k for $k < 2012$ provide a direct test of pre-trends: statistically indistinguishable-from-zero and stable estimates in the pre-period support the parallel trends assumption, while a systematic pattern in the pre-period coefficients would suggest that spouses of eligible and ineligible immigrants were already diverging prior to DACA for reasons unrelated to the policy. Coefficients β_k for $2012 \leq k \leq 2017$ trace the effect during the implementation period, and coefficients for $k \in \{2018, 2019\}$ trace the effect during the post-rescission-announcement uncertainty period, allowing a visual and statistical assessment of whether the estimated spillover is stable, growing, or fading once DACA's legal status became contested.

5 Results

5.1 Main Results

Table 2 presents the estimates from Equation (1). Column (1) reports the pooled difference-in-differences estimate across the full analysis sample of spouses linked to narrowly defined DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible immigrants. DACA eligibility increased spousal labor force participation by 4.1 percentage points during the implementation period (2012-2017, $p < 0.05$) and by 3.5 percentage points during the subsequent period of policy uncertainty following the 2017 rescission attempt (2018-2019, $p < 0.10$), relative to spouses of immigrants who narrowly missed the program’s eligibility criteria. The corresponding employment effects are similar in magnitude and, if anything, slightly larger during the uncertainty period: 3.6 percentage points during implementation and 4.3 percentage points thereafter, both statistically distinguishable from zero. The pre-period baseline coefficient, the estimated difference between spouses of eligible and ineligible partners prior to the policy’s implementation, is small in magnitude and statistically indistinguishable from zero in both outcomes, consistent with the narrow-band comparison design achieving balance between treatment and comparison groups on this margin.

Two features of these estimates are worth emphasizing. First, the effect does not decay with the onset of policy uncertainty; the point estimates for employment are, if anything, larger in 2018-2019 than during the initial implementation window, suggesting that the household-level labor supply response to a partner’s improved legal standing is not contingent on the perceived permanence of that standing. Second, the magnitude of the effect, roughly four percentage points on a base labor force participation rate in the high seventies, is economically meaningful, corresponding to an increase of approximately five percent relative to the pre-period mean among spouses of ineligible partners.

Figure 1 presents the event-study analogue of Column (1), plotting coefficients on the interaction between survey year and partner DACA eligibility, with 2011 as the omitted

reference year. The pre-period coefficients are small in magnitude and exhibit no discernible trend, consistent with the parallel pre-trends assumption underlying the difference-in-differences design. Beginning in 2012, the coefficients rise sharply and remain elevated through the end of the sample period in 2019, tracing out the same pattern of persistence documented in the pooled estimates above.

5.2 Evidence on Household Specialization: The Role of Partner Sex

If household specialization around childcare and earnings is a driving force behind the estimated spillover, the response should differ depending on which partner in the household gains legal status. Columns (2) and (3) of Table 2 split the sample by the sex of the DACA-eligible partner. The results reveal that the pooled effect documented above is driven almost entirely by households in which the DACA-eligible partner is male. For spouses of male partners, DACA eligibility increased labor force participation by 5.9 percentage points during implementation and 5.8 percentage points during the subsequent uncertainty period, both significant at the five percent level; employment effects follow the same pattern, rising from 4.4 to 6.5 percentage points across the two periods. By contrast, the estimated effects among spouses of female partners are an order of magnitude smaller, rarely exceed two percentage points in either outcome, and are not statistically distinguishable from zero in any specification.

This pattern stands in contrast to the classical added-worker-effect literature on intra-household labor supply, which documents wives increasing their labor market attachment in response to a husband's income loss or job displacement (Cullen and Gruber, 2000; Lundberg, 1985; Stephens, 2002). Here, spousal labor supply rises following an improvement, rather than a deterioration, in the husband's earnings prospects and formal-sector access, a pattern more consistent with a household-specialization or reduced-risk channel, in which the husband's improved standing relaxes a constraint on the wife's labor supply, than with a straightforward income-smoothing response to a negative shock.

Figure 2 presents the corresponding event-study estimates, separately for each outcome and each sex of partner. For female spouses of male DACA-eligible immigrants, the coefficients for both In Labor Force and Employed rise substantially after 2012 and remain elevated through 2019, mirroring the sustained ATT estimates in Table 2. The pre-period coefficients are largely stable and close to zero across both outcomes, aside from a single negative estimate in 2010 for the labor force event-study in panel (a); a formal power calculation indicates this result warrants somewhat more caution than the paper’s other findings.⁶ The qualitative pattern, a sustained, elevated effect concentrated among spouses of male partners, is broadly consistent with the difference-in-differences estimates in Table 2, though the pre-trend sensitivity documented above warrants some caution in interpreting this subsample’s magnitude.

For male spouses of female DACA-eligible immigrants, the pre-period coefficients are largely flat across both outcomes. Post-period point estimates are mostly close to zero and statistically insignificant, with the exception of two individual years showing significant effects in opposite directions and no consistent directional pattern across the period. This lack of a sustained response stands in contrast to the pattern for male partners and is broadly consistent with the near-zero average effects reported for this subgroup in Table 2, reinforcing the conclusion that the estimated spillover on spousal labor supply is not symmetric across the sex of the DACA-eligible partner.

5.3 Household Composition: The Role of Children

If the male-partner spillover reflects household specialization around childcare, its magnitude should depend on whether the household includes children. To test this, I split the sample by partner sex and by the presence of at least one child in the household,

⁶Following Roth (2022), I assess the robustness of the event-study estimates to potential pre-trend violations, reporting the power, Bayes factor, and likelihood ratio for each specification in Appendix Table A.1. The results favor true parallel trends over a hypothesized linear pre-trend violation large enough to explain the estimated effect for the overall specification. For the male-partner subsample, by contrast, the observed coefficients are more consistent with the hypothesized violation than with parallel trends.

re-estimating the event-study specification in Equation (2) separately for each group. Figures A.2 and A.3 show that pre-trends are stable among childless male-partner households for both outcomes and among households with children for the employment outcome; for labor force participation among male-partner households with children, however, the pre-trends are volatile, and the corresponding estimate should accordingly be interpreted with some caution.

The resulting average treatment effects support a household-specialization interpretation: the male-partner effect is concentrated almost entirely among households with children present. Among these households, DACA eligibility raised labor force participation by 7.1 percentage points during the implementation period and 6.2 percentage points during the subsequent period of policy uncertainty, both statistically significant; the corresponding employment effects, whose pre-trends are stable, are 5.8 and 7.0 percentage points. Among male-partner households without children, none of the four corresponding coefficients are statistically distinguishable from zero. Among female-partner households, by contrast, I find no comparable positive pattern in either the childless or child-present subsample, consistent with the asymmetric, gendered specialization documented in Section 5.

5.4 Evidence on Enforcement Risk: Spousal Citizenship Status

Because a spouse's own citizenship status shapes her direct exposure to immigration enforcement, it offers a natural margin for distinguishing a risk-pooling mechanism from a pure income effect. Columns (4) and (5) of Table 2 split the sample by the spouse's own citizenship status, a margin that speaks to the mechanism underlying the estimated spillover. A risk-pooling channel, in which an undocumented spouse limits her own labor market activity to reduce the household's aggregate exposure to immigration enforcement, predicts that the spillover should be concentrated among noncitizen spouses and should not extend to spouses who are themselves citizens. An income effect, by contrast, predicts

a similar response regardless of the spouse's own citizenship status.

The estimates are directionally consistent with the risk-pooling channel. Among noncitizen spouses, DACA eligibility increased labor force participation by 4.3 percentage points and employment by 5.2 percentage points during the implementation period, both significant at the five percent level. These effects attenuate substantially during the subsequent uncertainty period, falling to 1.1 and 2.3 percentage points respectively and losing statistical significance. Among citizen spouses, none of the four coefficients across both outcomes and both periods reach conventional significance thresholds, though several point estimates are directionally consistent with a delayed response emerging during the uncertainty period.

Figure 3 presents event-study estimates separately by spouse citizenship and outcome. For noncitizen spouses, both In Labor Force and Employed show a coherent run of positive, mostly significant coefficients concentrated in the early implementation period, from 2013 through 2016, followed by an attenuation to statistical insignificance from 2017 onward; the pre-period coefficients are uniformly small and statistically insignificant across both outcomes. For citizen spouses, the pre-period coefficients are similarly flat throughout, but the post-period pattern differs: In Labor Force shows only a marginally significant coefficient in 2017, while Employed shows significant, positive coefficients specifically in 2018 and 2019, consistent with a response that emerges later rather than fading, the opposite timing from the pattern observed among noncitizen spouses.

This contrast in timing, an early, fading response among noncitizen spouses and a later-emerging response among citizen spouses in the Employed outcome, is broadly consistent with the pooled Post and Uncertain period estimates in Table 2, though the event-study estimates reveal more precise timing within each period than the pooled coefficients alone convey. The clean pre-trends documented here across both subgroups lend additional credibility to this heterogeneity margin, suggesting that citizenship remains a theoretically motivated predictor of the spillover's magnitude and timing.

5.5 Robustness Checks

5.5.1 Selection into Marriage

The main results rely on comparing spouses of DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible partners, an approach that would be confounded if DACA eligibility itself changes who marries or whether a spouse is present in the household. To assess this concern, I estimate Equation (1) using the partner's own marriage-related outcomes as the dependent variable. Table A.2 shows that while eligible and ineligible partners differ in their baseline propensity to be married, the coefficient for the interaction term is small and statistically indistinguishable from zero for both outcomes. This suggests that DACA eligibility does not induce differential selection into marriage or spouse presence, easing concerns that the composition of the spousal sample changes with treatment.

5.5.2 Balance on Local Labor Market Conditions

Because the Great Recession (2007-2009) overlaps with the pre-period of my sample, a natural concern is that DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible partners were differentially exposed to local labor market conditions during this period, independent of DACA itself. The main specification already includes the Bartik shift-share measure of local labor demand and the change in the state house price index to account for local economic conditions. As an additional check, I test whether partner DACA eligibility, and its interaction with the Post and Uncertain period indicators, predicts four measures of commuting-zone-level economic conditions: the overall, immigrant, and citizen unemployment rates, and the Bartik-style shift-share measure itself. Table A.3 shows the results. Across all four measures, nearly every coefficient is statistically indistinguishable from zero; two of twelve interaction coefficients are marginally significant at the 10 percent level, but both are near zero in magnitude. This suggests that the estimated effects of DACA eligibility on spousal labor supply are unlikely to be driven by differential exposure to local labor market conditions

across the two comparison groups, either on average or specifically around the timing of the policy.

5.5.3 Robustness to Alternative Specifications

The main results rely on a comparison between spouses of narrowly defined DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible partners, an approach that assumes the two groups are otherwise similar in their observable characteristics and in the local economic conditions they face. To assess whether the main results are sensitive to these assumptions, I re-estimate the main specification under two alternative approaches. First, I add partner-side controls (age, age squared, and education) to account for any residual differences in the characteristics of the DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible partners themselves. Second, I replace year fixed effects with commuting-zone-specific linear time trends to account for the possibility that local labor markets were evolving along different trajectories independent of DACA. Figure A.4 shows that the estimated effects, and the corresponding event-study patterns, are consistent with the main results across both specifications, with the effect concentrated among male partners and, during the initial implementation period, among spouses of noncitizen partners.

6 Conclusion

This paper documents a spillover effect of DACA eligibility: a partner's access to legal work authorization raised spousal labor force participation and employment, an effect that persisted through the period of policy uncertainty following the 2017 rescission attempt rather than being contingent on it. The spillover appears concentrated primarily among female spouses of male DACA-eligible immigrants, and households where children are present, consistent with a household-specialization channel in which a partner's improved economic standing relaxes a constraint tying the other spouse's labor supply to childcare

and household risk considerations, though pre-trend sensitivity in this subsample warrants some caution in interpreting its magnitude. Heterogeneity by spouse citizenship is suggestive of an enforcement-risk channel operating alongside this mechanism, though the timing of the effects warrants further investigation.

These results speak to a broader question than whether household spillovers exist. Individually targeted policies are routinely evaluated, and their budgets justified, using estimates of effects on recipients alone. The findings here suggest that this approach can miss a substantial share of a policy's total labor market effect, and that the missed share may depend systematically on household composition, so a policy's aggregate impact may not be recoverable by simply scaling up the recipient-level estimate. This has potential implications for how agencies size the labor market consequences of immigration status programs, and for how such programs compare against alternatives, such as family-based visa reforms, whose spillovers may operate through different household channels. More broadly, that this spillover persisted through a period in which the underlying protection was itself contested is suggestive that the value of temporary legal status may not depend on that status being permanent, a consideration potentially relevant to the design of any policy granting renewable, rather than durable, legal protections.

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Figures and Tables

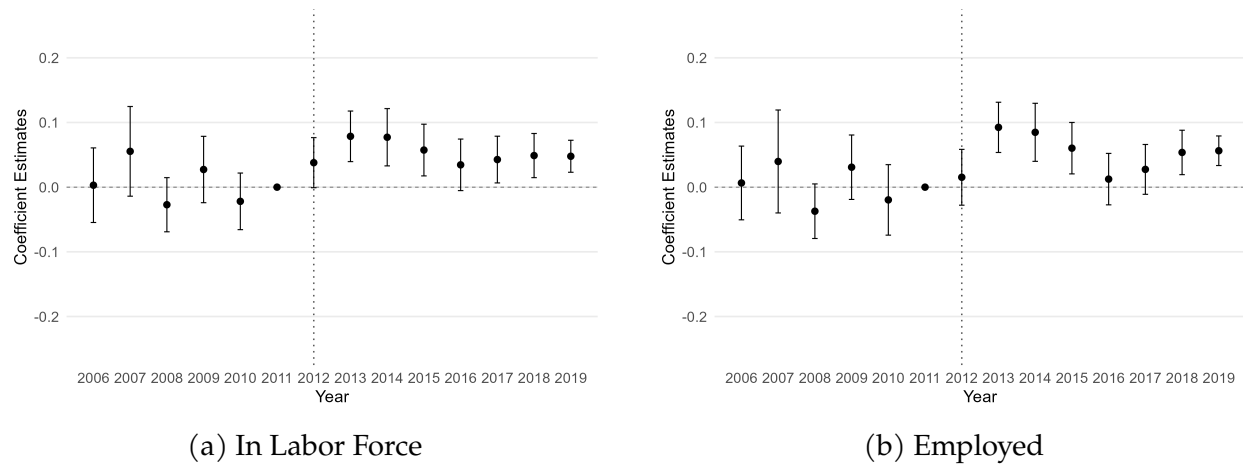
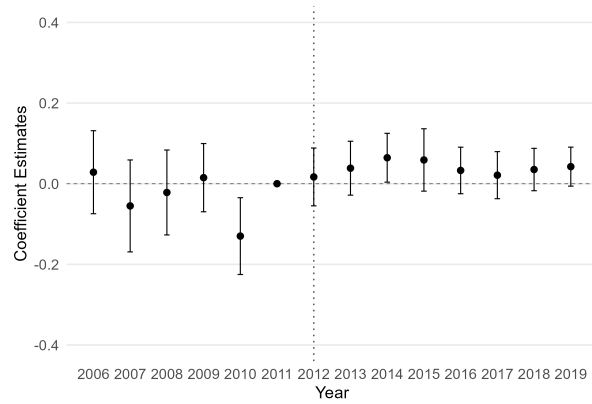
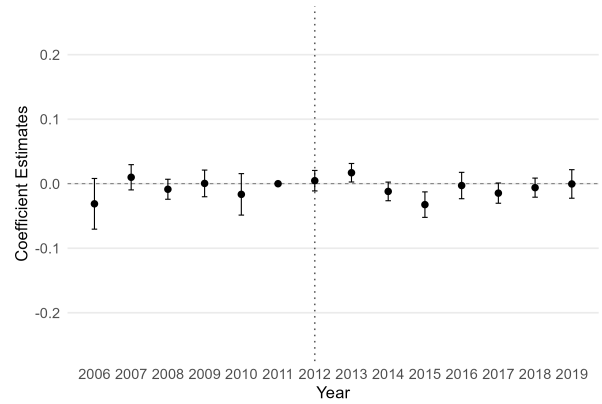


Figure 1: Event Study: Spousal Labor Supply Outcomes

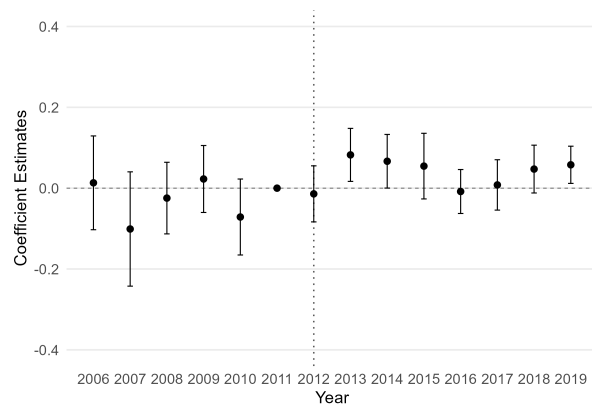
Notes: Event-study coefficients for spouses of DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible immigrants, with spouses who are themselves DACA-eligible excluded from the sample. Treatment is defined as $DACA_i$ interacted with indicators for each survey year. 2011, the final year before implementation, serves as the omitted reference period. Vertical dashed line denotes DACA's 2012 implementation. Standard errors are clustered by state, and vertical bars depict 95 percent confidence intervals.



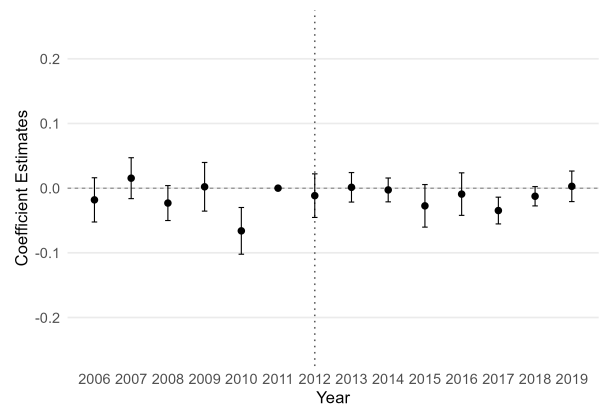
(a) In Labor Force (Male DACA Recipient)



(b) In Labor Force (Female DACA Recipient)



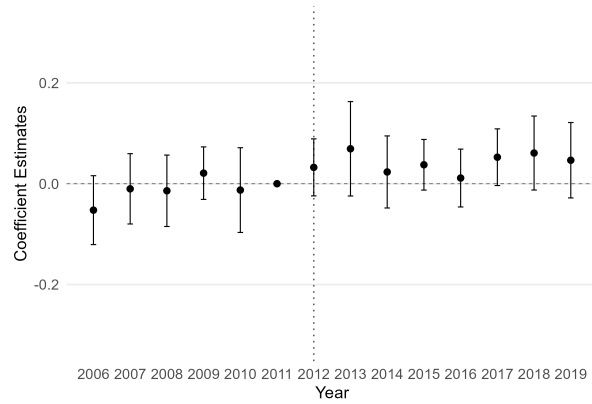
(c) Employed (Male DACA Recipient)



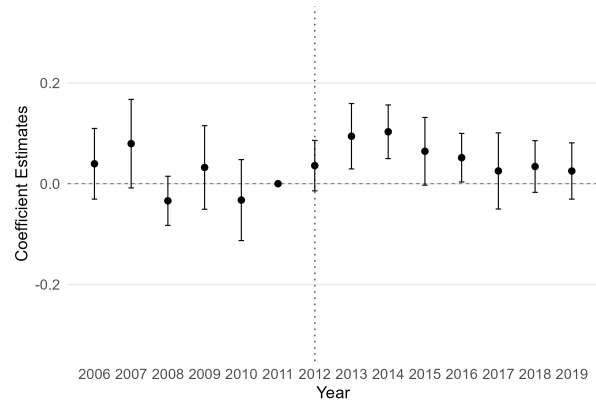
(d) Employed (Female DACA Recipient)

Figure 2: Event Study: Spousal Labor Supply by Sex of DACA-Eligible Immigrant

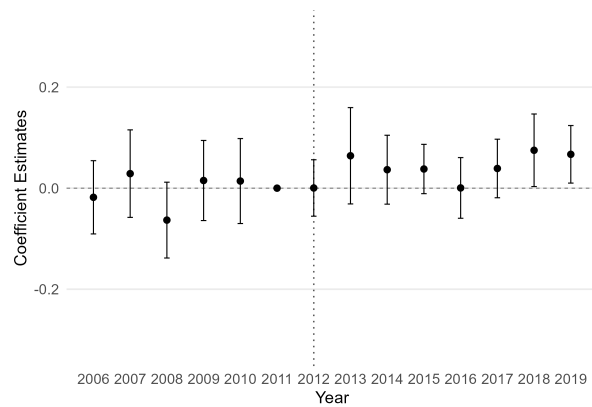
Notes: Event-study coefficients for spouses of DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible partners, estimated separately for male and female partners. 2011 serves as the omitted reference year. Vertical dashed line denotes DACA's 2012 implementation. Standard errors are clustered by state, and vertical bars depict 95 percent confidence intervals.



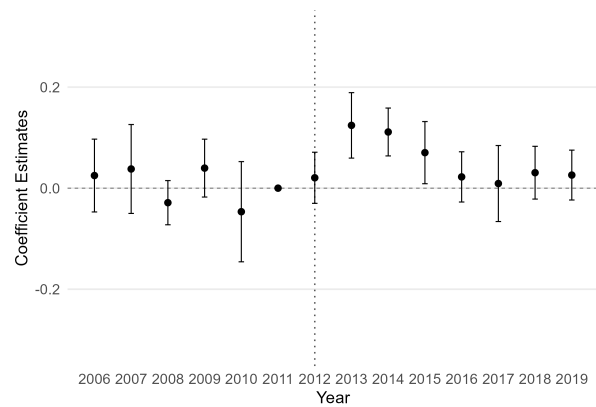
(a) In Labor Force (Citizen Spouse)



(b) In Labor Force (Noncitizen Spouse)



(c) Employed (Citizen Spouse)



(d) Employed (Noncitizen Spouse)

Figure 3: Event Study: Spousal Labor Supply by Spouse's Own Citizenship

Notes: Event-study coefficients for spouses of DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible partners, estimated separately by the spouse's own citizenship status. 2011 serves as the omitted reference year. Vertical dashed line denotes DACA's 2012 implementation. Standard errors are clustered by state, and vertical bars depict 95 percent confidence intervals.

Table 1: Summary Statistics: Pre-Period (2006-2011)

Variable	Partner DACA-Ineligible		Partner DACA-Eligible	
	Mean	SD	Mean	SD
In labor force	0.789	0.408	0.810	0.393
Employed	0.736	0.441	0.748	0.434
Age	27.20	5.63	26.50	5.34
White	0.055	0.228	0.070	0.255
Black	0.003	0.050	0.009	0.096
Other race	0.006	0.077	0.012	0.108
Latino	0.937	0.244	0.909	0.288
No high school	0.109	0.312	0.090	0.287
Some high school	0.119	0.324	0.140	0.347
High school	0.544	0.498	0.503	0.500
High school plus	0.217	0.412	0.251	0.434
English well	0.543	0.498	0.658	0.475
English perfect	0.060	0.237	0.107	0.309
Number of children	1.30	1.06	1.27	1.08
Noncitizen spouse	0.690	0.463	0.535	0.499
Partner age	24.30	2.71	23.90	2.72
Partner no high school	0.007	0.086	0.004	0.063
Partner some high school	0.010	0.098	0.015	0.121
Partner high school	0.819	0.385	0.743	0.437
Partner high school plus	0.164	0.370	0.238	0.426
Partner year of immigration	2001	2.42	1994	5.18
Partner years in U.S.	11.0	2.42	17.8	5.18
Observations	3,023		7,695	
Unique individual-years	2,441		6,175	

Notes: Means and standard deviations are weighted using the PUMA-to-CZ-adjusted person weight (ACS person weight $\times$ PUMA-to-CZ population allocation factor). Sample restricted to spouses of DACA-eligible or DACA-ineligible partners observed in survey years 2006-2011, excluding spouses who are themselves DACA-eligible.

Table 2: Effect of DACA Eligibility on Spousal Labor Supply

	(1) Overall	(2) Male DACA Recipient Female Spouse	(3) Female DACA Recipient Male Spouse	(4) Citizen Spouse	(5) Immigrant Spouse
<i>Panel A: In Labor Force</i>					
DACA-Eligible	0.014 (0.013)	-0.019 (0.021)	-0.013** (0.005)	0.004 (0.019)	0.018 (0.017)
DACA-Eligible $\times$ Post	0.041** (0.016)	0.059** (0.026)	0.007 (0.005)	0.034 (0.021)	0.043** (0.020)
DACA-Eligible $\times$ Uncertain	0.035* (0.017)	0.058** (0.028)	0.010 (0.010)	0.049 (0.030)	0.011 (0.023)
<i>Panel B: Employed</i>					
DACA-Eligible	0.012 (0.014)	-0.012 (0.019)	-0.020** (0.009)	0.021 (0.017)	0.006 (0.019)
DACA-Eligible $\times$ Post	0.036* (0.018)	0.044* (0.024)	0.006 (0.010)	0.010 (0.019)	0.052** (0.023)
DACA-Eligible $\times$ Uncertain	0.043** (0.019)	0.065** (0.027)	0.017 (0.013)	0.050 (0.031)	0.023 (0.025)
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
CZ Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	41,488	19,171	22,317	21,838	19,650
Unique individual-years	30,017	12,583	15,150	14,710	12,786

Notes: Difference-in-differences estimates for spouses of DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible partners, excluding spouses who are themselves DACA-eligible. *DACA-Eligible* is the baseline coefficient on partner eligibility, measured in the pre-period. *Post* is an indicator for survey years 2012-2017; *Uncertain* is an indicator for survey years 2018-2019, following the DACA rescission attempt. Column (1) is the full sample. Columns (2) and (3) split the sample by the sex of the DACA-eligible partner. Columns (4) and (5) split the sample by the spouse's own citizenship status. All columns include spousal-side controls (age, age squared, education, English proficiency, race/ethnicity) and state and county policy controls (immigration enforcement indicators, sanctuary population share, Bartik shift-share instrument, minimum wage, house price index change), commuting-zone and year fixed effects, and no partner-side controls. All regressions weighted by the PUMA-to-CZ-adjusted person weight. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Supplemental Appendix

A Additional Figures and Tables

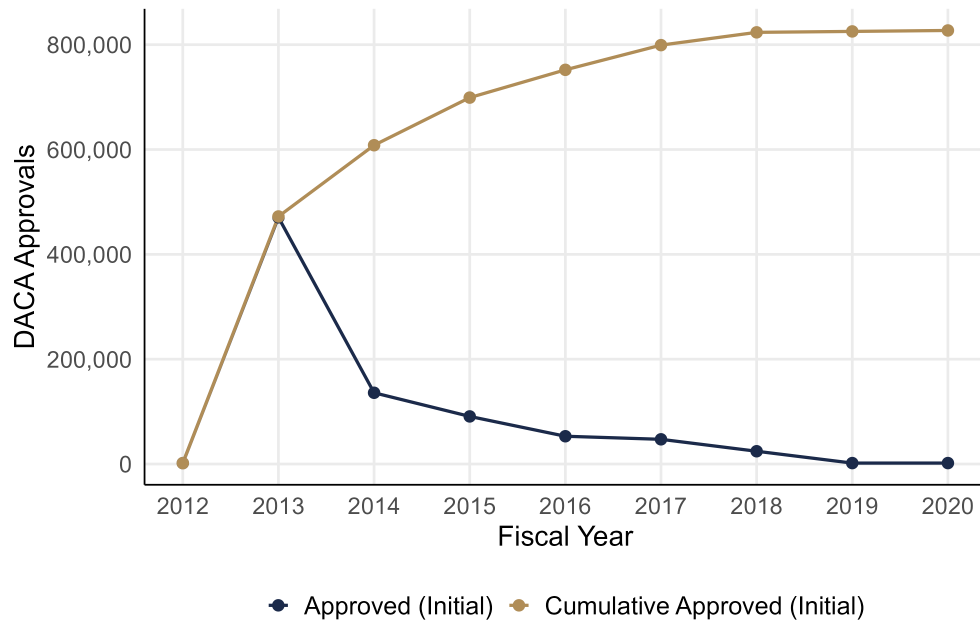
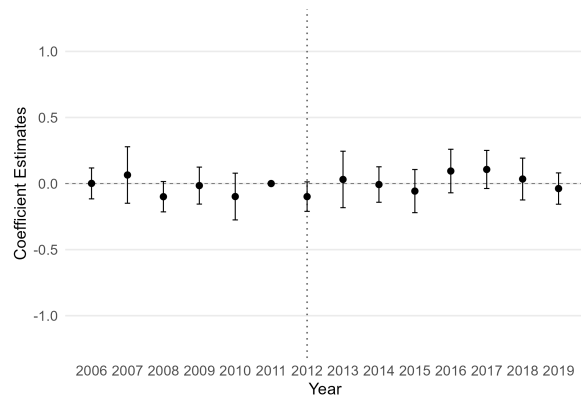
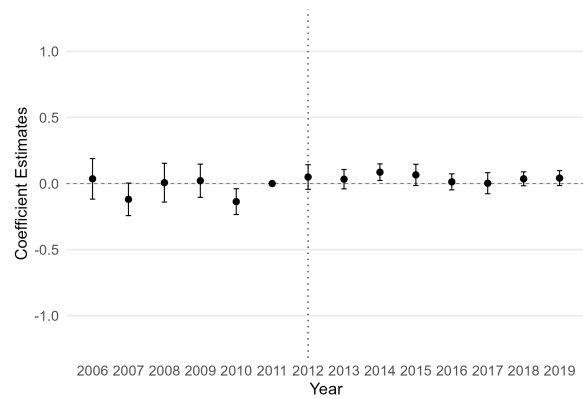


Figure A.1: DACA Initial Approvals: Annual and Cumulative (FY2012-FY2020)

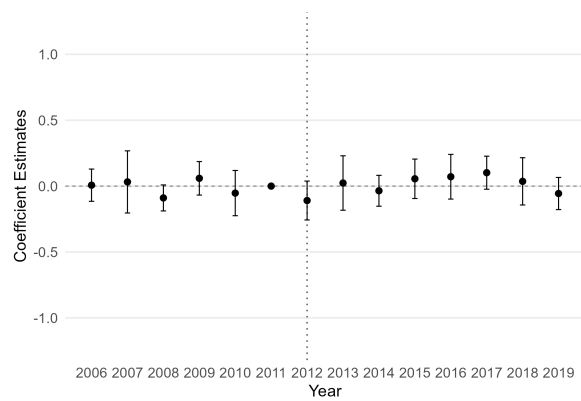
Notes: Annual and cumulative counts of approved initial DACA applications, by fiscal year. Fiscal years run from October 1 to September 30. Source: U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services, DACA Performance Data.



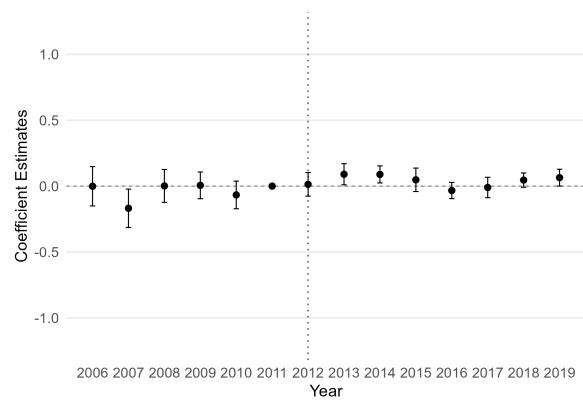
(a) In Labor Force (No Child)



(b) In Labor Force (Has Child)



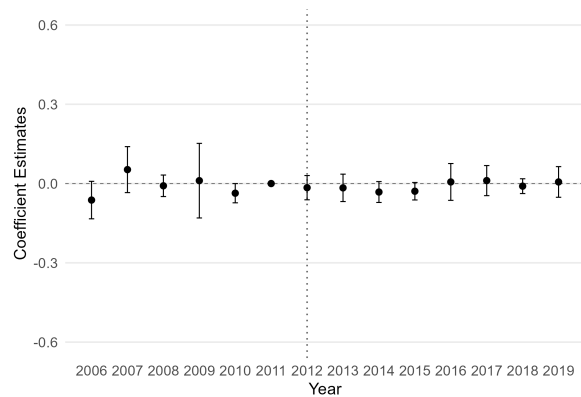
(c) Employed (No Child)



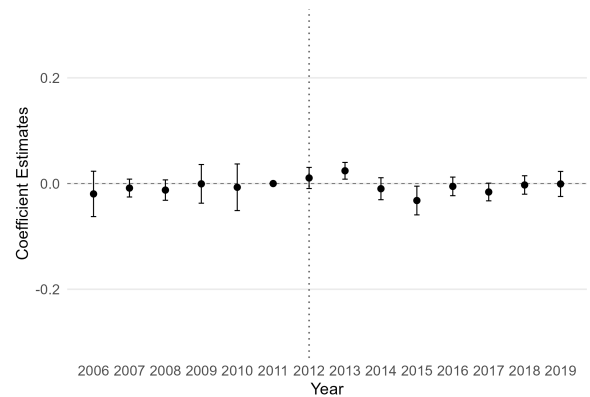
(d) Employed (Has Child)

Figure A.2: Event Study: Spousal Labor Supply by Household Composition, Male DACA Recipient

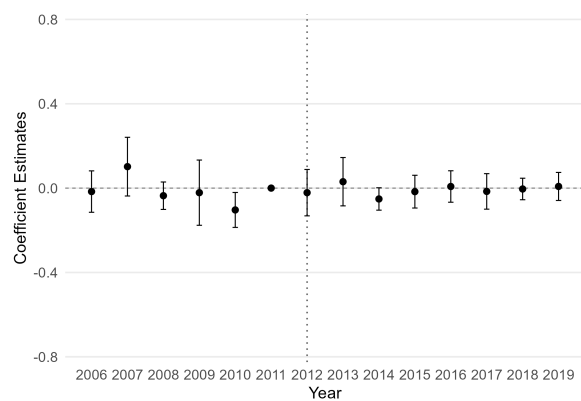
Notes: Event-study coefficients for spouses of DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible male partners, estimated separately by the presence of at least one child in the household. 2011 serves as the omitted reference year. The vertical dashed line denotes DACA's 2012 implementation. Standard errors are clustered by state, and vertical bars depict 95 percent confidence intervals.



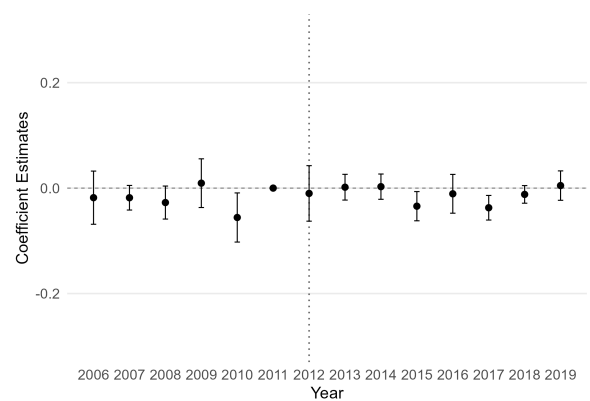
(a) In Labor Force (No Child)



(b) In Labor Force (Has Child)



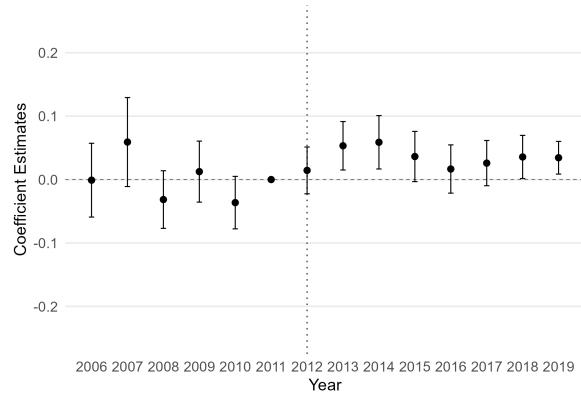
(c) Employed (No Child)



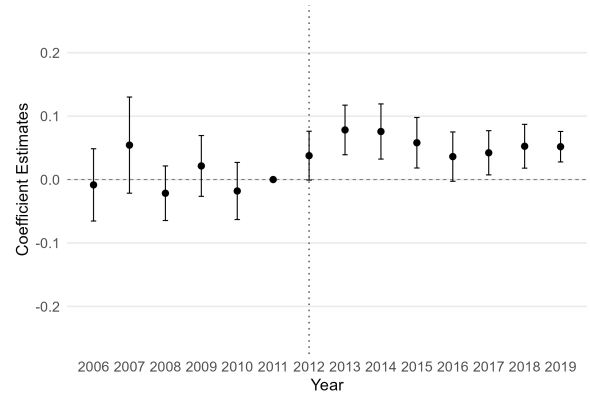
(d) Employed (Has Child)

Figure A.3: Event Study: Spousal Labor Supply by Household Composition, Female DACA Recipient

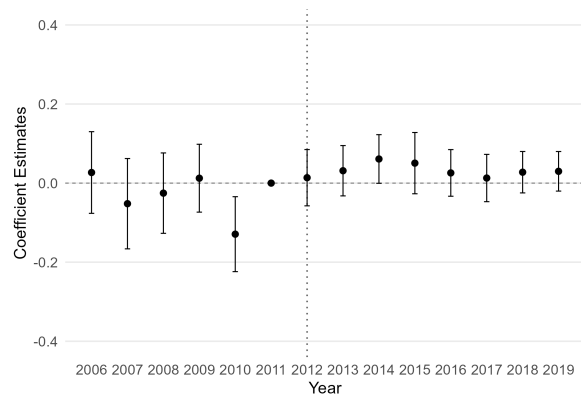
Notes: Event-study coefficients for spouses of DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible female partners, estimated separately by the presence of at least one child in the household. 2011 serves as the omitted reference year. The vertical dashed line denotes DACA's 2012 implementation. Standard errors are clustered by state, and vertical bars depict 95 percent confidence intervals.



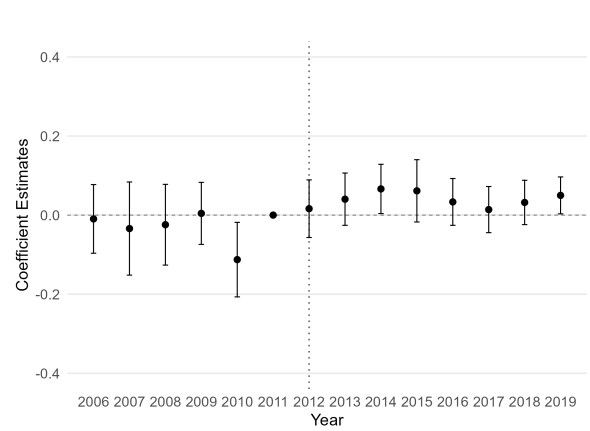
(a) Overall (DACA Recipient Controls)



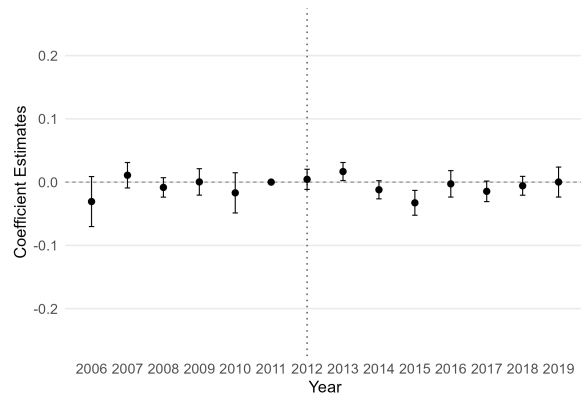
(b) Overall (CZ Trends)



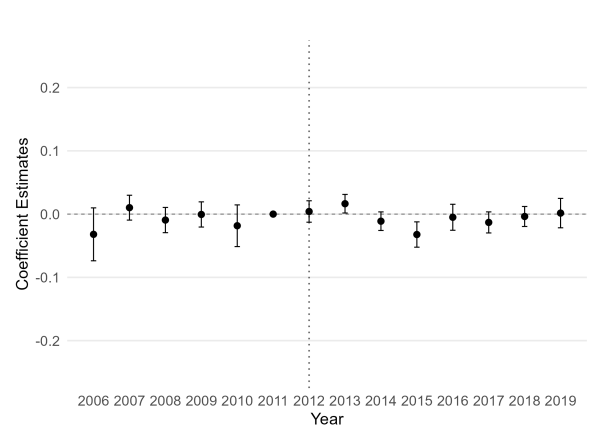
(c) Male DACA Recipient (DACA Recipient Controls)



(d) Male DACA Recipient (CZ Trends)

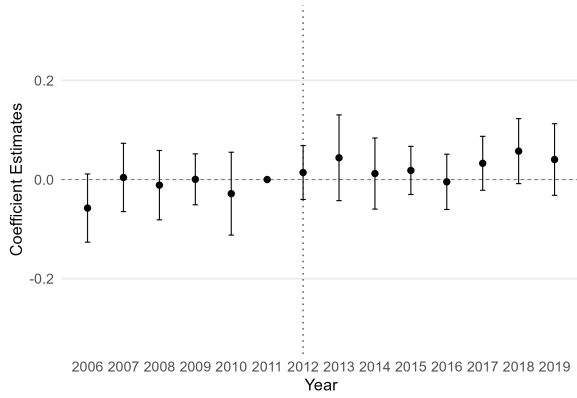


(e) Female DACA Recipient (DACA Recipient Controls)

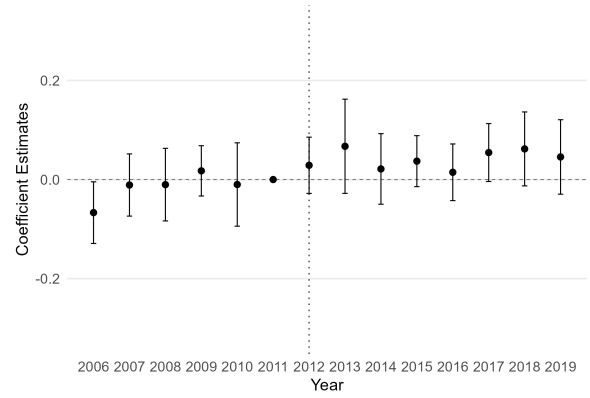


(f) Female DACA Recipient (CZ Trends)

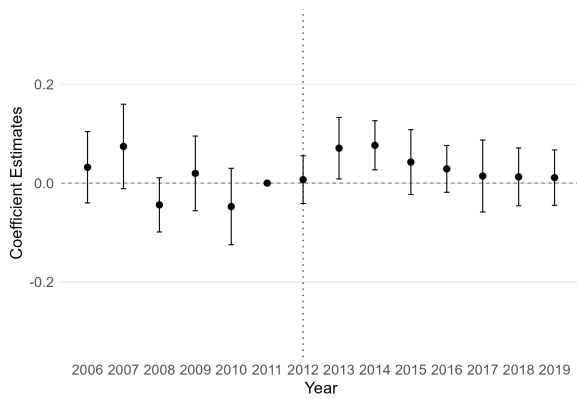
Figure A.4: Event Study: In Labor Force, Across Sample Splits and Robustness Specifications



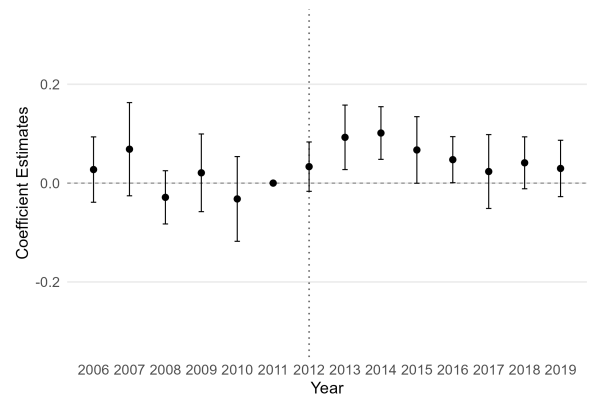
(g) Citizen Spouse (DACA Recipient Controls)



(h) Citizen Spouse (CZ Trends)



(i) Immigrant Spouse (DACA Recipient Controls)



(j) Immigrant Spouse (CZ Trends)

Figure A.4: Event Study: In Labor Force, Across Sample Splits and Robustness Specifications (continued)

Notes: Event-study coefficients for spouses of DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible partners under two robustness specifications: with partner-side controls (left column) and with commuting-zone-specific linear time trends (right column). Rows correspond to the overall sample and four sample splits (sex of the DACA-eligible partner, spouse's own citizenship status). 2011 serves as the omitted reference year. The vertical dashed line denotes DACA's 2012 implementation. Standard errors are clustered by state, and vertical bars depict 95 percent confidence intervals.

Table A.1: Power Calculations for Pre-Trend Violations (Roth, 2022)

Specification	Power	Bayes Factor	Likelihood Ratio
In Labor Force (Overall)	0.79	0.26	0.0004
Employed (Overall)	0.79	0.27	0.0016
In Labor Force (Male Partner)	0.41	0.75	2.65
Employed (Male Partner)	0.40	0.76	4.06
In Labor Force (Female Partner)	1.00	0.00	0.00
Employed (Female Partner)	0.99	0.01	0.03
In Labor Force (Citizen Spouse)	0.64	0.46	0.56
In Labor Force (Immigrant Spouse)	0.64	0.46	0.0003
Employed (Citizen Spouse)	0.59	0.52	0.73
Employed (Immigrant Spouse)	0.67	0.42	0.0045

Notes: Power, Bayes factor, and likelihood ratio for a hypothesized linear pre-trend violation calibrated to fully explain the estimated Post-period treatment effect for each specification, following Roth (2022). A likelihood ratio above 1 indicates the observed event-study coefficients are more consistent with the hypothesized violation than with true parallel trends.

Table A.2: Effect of DACA Eligibility on Marriage: Selection into the DACA Recipient Sample

	(1) Married (Spouse Present)	(2) Married (Broad)
DACA-Eligible	-0.041*** (0.006)	-0.036*** (0.007)
DACA-Eligible $\times$ Post	-0.003 (0.007)	-0.009 (0.009)
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes
State Policy Controls	Yes	Yes
CZ Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes
Year Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes
Observations	141,268	141,268
Unique individual-years	105,482	105,482

Notes: Difference-in-differences estimates of the effect of DACA eligibility on the partner's own marriage status, estimated on the sample of DACA-eligible and narrowly ineligible partners used to construct the main analysis sample. *Married (Spouse Present)* indicates the partner is married with a spouse present in the household; *Married (Broad)* additionally includes partners who are married with a spouse absent. *DACA-Eligible* is the baseline coefficient on eligibility, measured in the pre-period; *Post* is an indicator for survey years 2012 and later. Both columns include individual-level controls (age, age squared, education, English proficiency, race/ethnicity) and state and county policy controls (immigration enforcement indicators, sanctuary population share, Bartik shift-share instrument, minimum wage, house price index change), commuting-zone and year fixed effects. All regressions weighted by the PUMA-to-CZ-adjusted person weight. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.3: Balance on Local Labor Market Conditions

	Unemployment Rate	Immigrant Unemp Rate	Citizen Unemp Rate	Bartik Shift-Share
<i>Panel A: Immigrant DACA-Eligible (Level Balance)</i>				
Immigrant DACA-Eligible	-0.0001 (0.0002)	-0.0001 (0.0003)	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.0001 (0.0001)
<i>Panel B: Balance in Treatment Timing</i>				
Immigrant DACA-Eligible	-0.0005 (0.0005)	-0.0002 (0.0006)	-0.0006 (0.0005)	0.0001 (0.0003)
Immigrant DACA-Eligible $\times$ Post	0.0008* (0.0005)	0.0002 (0.0007)	0.0009* (0.0005)	-0.0001 (0.0003)
Immigrant DACA-Eligible $\times$ Uncertain	0.0000 (0.0009)	-0.0001 (0.0009)	0.0001 (0.0009)	-0.0008* (0.0005)
CZ Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	41,488	41,488	41,488	41,488
Unique individual-years	30,017	30,017	30,017	30,017

Notes: Each column reports regressions of a commuting-zone-level economic indicator on partner DACA eligibility (Panel A) or its interaction with the *Post* (2012–2017) and *Uncertain* (2018–2019) period indicators (Panel B), with commuting-zone and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

B Control Variables

B.1 Immigration Enforcement and Policy Control Variables

I compile data on immigration enforcement timing from several sources. Specifically, I collect information on the timing of 287(g) program adoption at the county and state levels from Kostandini et al. (2014), E-Verify implementation from Orrenius and Zavodny (2015), and state-level omnibus immigration laws from Allen and McNeely (2017) and Luo and Kostandini (2023), where for each county I identify the earliest adoption date of any sanctuary policy at the city, county, or state level. I verify these data against official records from ICE and the DHS.

Each of the five policy controls (described below) is constructed as the population-weighted share of a CZ in which the policy was active, aggregated across constituent counties and months. For a commuting zone c in year t , let ω_n denote county n 's share of the CZ's total population and $m_{n,t}$ denote the number of months in year t during which the policy was in effect in county n . The control is then

$$\text{Policy}_{c,t} = \sum_{n \in c} \omega_n \times \frac{m_{n,t}}{12},$$

so that a CZ composed of a single county with the policy active for the full year takes a value of one, a CZ with the policy active in half its population for the full year takes a value of 0.5, and a CZ where the policy is active for only part of the year is weighted accordingly by the fraction of months elapsed. State-level policies are assigned to every county within the state before this aggregation, so that all counties in an affected state receive full weight on the state-level measure regardless of county-level enforcement status. The immigration enforcement policies I consider are explained below.

287(g) County Agreements. Introduced under Section 287(g) of the Immigration and Nationality Act (added by the 1996 IIRIRA), these agreements permit ICE to deputize

local law enforcement officers to carry out specified immigration-enforcement duties under federal oversight. County-level 287(g) programs most commonly operate within jail intake, though in some jurisdictions and periods they extend to patrol or task-force settings, allowing designated officers to flag and process removable immigrants encountered in the course of ordinary policing. An indicator for whether a county maintained an active 287(g) agreement in a given year is included to absorb this source of local enforcement variation.

287(g) State Agreements. Beyond county-level participation, several states entered into 287(g) agreements through statewide agencies such as state police or corrections departments, extending enforcement authority across jurisdictions that had not independently adopted their own county-level programs. A separate state-level 287(g) indicator captures this broader layer of enforcement exposure not otherwise reflected in the county-level measure.

E-Verify Mandates. E-Verify is a federal, internet-based system that allows employers to confirm a newly hired worker's employment eligibility against government records. Rather than operating through police contact, E-Verify raises the cost employers face when hiring unauthorized workers directly. A number of states required E-Verify participation, for some or all employers, at various points during the sample period, and a state-level mandate indicator is included to account for this employer-facing channel of enforcement, distinct from police-based mechanisms.

Secure Communities. Secure Communities was a federal program under which local agencies automatically forwarded booking fingerprints to federal immigration databases, regardless of the severity of the underlying charge. It rolled out progressively by county starting in 2008, reaching near-universal coverage by 2013. An indicator for active county-level Secure Communities coverage is included to capture this additional source of local enforcement intensity.

Omnibus State Immigration Legislation. A subset of states passed broad omnibus immigration statutes that combined several enforcement and restriction provisions into a single legislative package, potentially covering employment verification requirements, benefit-eligibility checks, access to driver’s licenses or in-state tuition, and expanded authority for local police to enforce immigration law. Because these laws can shift the overall environment facing immigrant households along multiple margins simultaneously, an indicator for active omnibus legislation is included at the state-year level.

B.2 Sanctuary Policies

I use data on county-level sanctuary policy adoption from Martínez-Schuldt and Martínez (2019). Sanctuary jurisdictions limit local law enforcement cooperation with federal immigration authorities, typically by barring officers from asking about immigration status, declining ICE detainer requests, or restricting information-sharing with federal agencies. Since such policies can dampen the practical enforcement consequences of a given federal or state initiative by severing the link between local police contact and federal immigration action, a control is constructed identifying, for each county, the earliest date at which any city-, county-, or state-level sanctuary policy took effect; a county-year is coded as treated if the policy was in effect for at least six months of that year. I aggregate this county-level to the CZ level using each county’s baseline population share of the CZ, so that the resulting control captures the population-weighted share of each CZ under an active sanctuary policy in a given year.

B.3 Minimum wage

I obtain state minimum wage data from the Benzippere Historical Minimum Wage Database (Vaghul and Zipperer, 2016).

B.4 Housing Boom Control

As an additional control, I capture each state's exposure to the pre-recession housing boom and bust using house price data from the Federal Housing Finance Agency (FHFA). Similar to the approach in East et al. (2023), I construct a population-weighted, county-level FHFA house price index for each state, evaluated at 2000 and 2006, and calculate the percentage change between these two years as a fixed measure of the state's housing market exposure. Because this measure is time-invariant by construction, I interact it with linear and quadratic time trends, allowing states with different degrees of housing boom exposure to follow flexibly different trajectories over the sample period.

B.5 Bartik Local Labor Demand Index

Following Bartik (1991), I construct a shift-share variable to proxy for local labor demand conditions unrelated to DACA eligibility, combining each state's pre-period industry mix with subsequent national sectoral employment growth (Autor and Dorn, 2013; Goldsmith-Pinkham et al., 2020). Because the resulting predicted demand series depends only on a fixed base-year industry structure and on national, not state-level, employment growth, it captures demand-side variation that is plausibly unrelated to local DACA-eligible population size or composition.

Formally, the shift-share measure for state i in year t is given by

$$B_{i,t} = \sum_m (s_{i,m,0} \times g_{m,t}), \quad (3)$$

where $s_{i,m,0}$ is the share of employment in industry m and state i in the baseline year, 1997, and $g_{m,t}$ is the national growth rate of industry m in year t relative to the baseline year. The growth variable is given by

$$g_{m,t} = \frac{Emp_{m,t}}{Emp_{m,0}}, \quad (4)$$

where $Emp_{m,t}$ and $Emp_{m,0}$ denote total national employment in industry m in year t and in the baseline year, respectively. I construct this variable using the Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages (QCEW) from the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS). Because this measure is constructed from national growth rates rather than local outcomes, it provides an exogenous source of variation that helps isolate the effects of other factors, such as immigration enforcement, on spousal labor market outcomes. An index value near one indicates predicted labor demand close to its base-year level, while values above one reflect positive predicted growth relative to 1997. This variable enters all regressions as a time-varying control for local labor demand shocks unrelated to immigration enforcement or DACA eligibility.